Ashish Adhikari

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EDUCATION

The Ohio State University, Columbus, OH, USA Expected 2027
Ph.D. in Agricultural, Environmental, and Development Economics

University of Georgia, Athens, GA, USA 2020–2022
M.S. in Agricultural and Applied Economics

Agriculture and Forestry University, Rampur, Chitwan, Nepal 2013–2018
B.Sc. in Agriculture

FIELDS OF RESEARCH

Development Economics; Agricultural Economics

DISSERTATION

1. "Does Political Reservation Affect Program Implementation? Evidence from India" *solo-authored.*
2. "Does Trade Stabilize Food Prices Evenly During a Supply Shock? Evidence from India's Pulses Market" *with Ian Sheldon.* Under Review.
3. "Effects of Unmet Son Preference on Fertility Responses and Child Health: Evidence from South Asia" *with Leah Bevis.*

WORKING PAPERS

1. "Planting, Harvest, and Hope: Agricultural Production and Migration Aspirations" *with Tom Whittington and Alexis Villacis.* Under review.
2. "Irrigation in Transition: Changing Patterns of Groundwater Use in Nepal" *with Leah Bevis, Avinash Kishore, and Anton Urfels.* Revise and Resubmit at *Agricultural Water Management.*

ONGOING WORK

1. "Political Power and Public Health: Examining the Effects of Low-Caste Representation on Child Health in India" *with Karan Shakya and Jongeun Park.*
2. "Does Workfare Build Water Security? Evidence from Rural India" *with Charity Troyer Moore.*

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Associate August 2022 – Present
Department of Agricultural, Environmental, and Development Economics, The Ohio State University

Graduate Research Assistant August 2020 – May 2022
Department of Agricultural and Applied Economics, University of Georgia

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Lead Instructor January 2026 – May 2026
Data Analysis for Agribusiness and Applied Economics (AEDE 2005), The Ohio State University

- Independently designed and taught the course, including lectures and exams, to 14 undergraduate students.
- Student evaluation: 4.75/5.0 overall; 9.6/10 teaching effectiveness.

Lab Instructor August 2025 – December 2025
Data Analysis for Agribusiness and Applied Economics (AEDE 2005), The Ohio State University

- Led lab sessions on data management and statistical analysis in Excel for 36 undergraduate students.
- Student evaluation: 4.79/5.0 overall; 9.3/10 teaching effectiveness.

Graduate Teaching Assistant August 2021 – December 2021
Intermediate Economic Principles (AAEC 3580), University of Georgia

- Led weekly recitation sessions on intermediate microeconomics for 48 undergraduate students.

Instructor April 2019 – December 2020
Agricultural Economics, Shree Tribhuwan Model Secondary School, Nepal

- Taught agricultural economics to secondary students (grades 9–12); developed lesson plans and applied real-world examples.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Research Associate June 2025
Inclusion Economics India Centre

- Conducted fieldwork across four districts in Bihar, India, including interviews with local residents and government stakeholders.

Communications Coordinator August 2021 – August 2022
Agricultural and Applied Economics Association, International Section

- Coordinated communications and outreach to strengthen member engagement and the section's visibility across the international agricultural economics community.

Assistant Agriculture Officer June 2018 – December 2018
Nature's Conservation Private Limited, Kathmandu, Nepal

- Conducted field visits across 18 communities, leading focus groups and rural appraisals to prepare a climate change adaptation strategy for a local rural municipality.

Research Intern December 2017 – May 2018
Prime Minister Agriculture Modernization Project (PMAMP), Nepal

- Conducted farmer training sessions and field observations and completed a descriptive study of improved and hybrid rice adoption.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

2026 Agricultural and Applied Economics Association (AAEA) Annual Meeting, *Kansas City, MO* — Jul. 2026

15th Annual Conference of the American Society of Health Economists (ASHEcon), *Minneapolis, MN* — Jun. 2026

North American Summer Meeting of the Econometric Society, *Atlanta, GA* — Jun. 2026

59th Annual Meeting of the Southern Agricultural Economics Association (SAEA), *Louisville, KY* — Feb. 2026

7th Annual Scientific Symposium, Feed the Future Innovation Lab for Nutrition, *Kathmandu, Nepal* — Dec. 2019

International Conference on Mountains in the Changing World, *Kathmandu, Nepal* — Oct. 2019

HONORS AND AWARDS

- Graduate Assistantship, Department of Agricultural, Environmental, and Development Economics, The Ohio State University.
- Graduate Assistantship, Department of Agricultural and Applied Economics, University of Georgia.
- Full Scholarship for Undergraduate Studies, Agriculture and Forestry University, Nepal.
- Undergraduate Thesis Grant, Agriculture and Forestry University, Nepal.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE AND MEMBERSHIPS

- **Referee:** *Journal of Agribusiness in Developing and Emerging Economies*
- **Member:** The Econometric Society; Agricultural and Applied Economics Association (AAEA)

LEADERSHIP AND COMMUNITY SERVICE

- Event Manager, Nepalese Student Association, University of Georgia, August 2020 – May 2022.
- Vice President, Nepalese Youth for Climate Action, Chitwan, January 2017 – November 2017.
- Technical Coordinator, Nepal Terai Students' Committee, January 2014 – November 2017.

SKILLS

Software Stata, R, LaTeX, Google Earth Engine
Languages Maithili (mother tongue); Nepali (native); English (fluent); Hindi (fluent)

REFERENCES

All at the Department of Agricultural, Environmental, and Development Economics, The Ohio State University.

Ian Sheldon
Andersons Chair of Agricultural Marketing, Trade and Policy
Email: sheldon.1@osu.edu

Leah Bevis
Associate Professor
Email: bevis.16@osu.edu

Charity Troyer Moore
Research Assistant Professor
Email: moore.1736@osu.edu

ABSTRACTS

Does Political Reservation Affect Program Implementation? Evidence from India

solo-authored

Political reservation brings disadvantaged groups into elected leadership and can change policy choices and the distribution of public benefits, but less is known about its effects on the scale and implementation of public programs. These margins matter because they determine how many public assets are built and how many paid workdays are generated. I examine how reserving village council leadership for Scheduled Castes (SCs), Other Backward Classes (OBCs), and women affects the number of public works approved and shares of those works that are completed or abandoned. I construct a novel panel dataset from administrative records covering approximately 10 million public works across two council terms in Uttar Pradesh. Using two-way fixed effects, with a fuzzy regression discontinuity design as a complementary identification strategy, I find that SC reservation reduces the number of approved works by about 7 percent and raises the abandonment rate among approved works by 3.4 percent relative to its mean. SC reservation also reduces paid employment by 11 percent, equivalent to about 5.4 million fewer workdays across Uttar Pradesh each year. The effects are smaller under OBC reservation, while women's reservation has no consistent effect. The SC implementation gap is concentrated in community projects and narrows over the council term, consistent with learning.

Effects of Unmet Son Preference on Fertility Responses and Child Health: Evidence from South Asia

with Leah Bevis

This paper provides a unified, cross-country assessment of how unmet son preference shapes fertility and child health across South Asia, leveraging quasi-random variation in firstborn sex. First, we show that son preference, activated by a firstborn daughter, reduces contraceptive use, shortens birth intervals, and reduces breastfeeding duration. These responses are pronounced in India, Nepal, and Pakistan but substantially weaker in Bangladesh. Second, we show that son preference also affects child health, with estimates concentrated in India. Second-born girls with an older sister are shorter and lighter than those with an older brother, while second-born boys with an older sister are taller and heavier. Third, we document asymmetric survival responses consistent with activated son preference: girls' survival is unaffected, but boys born after a sister are more likely to survive. Overall, the findings suggest that unmet son preference continues to shape fertility behavior and generate unequal child health outcomes.

Does Trade Stabilize Food Prices Evenly During a Supply Shock? Evidence from India's Pulses Market

with Ian Sheldon

Developing countries often rely on trade policy to stabilize food prices during supply disruptions, yet the spatial distribution of these benefits remains poorly understood. This paper studies India's 2015–2016 pulses crisis, when consecutive domestic production shortfalls sharply raised pulses prices and triggered a surge in imports. We examine whether trade-based price stabilization reached domestic markets evenly or weakened with distance from major import ports. Using a district-level panel of wholesale pulses prices from 2009 to 2019 and a difference-in-differences design, we show that the import surge did not provide uniform price relief. During the crisis, each additional 100 kilometers from a major import port translated into about a 1.7 percent larger increase in pulses prices. This means that a district at the 90th percentile of port distance faced a price increase about 12 percent larger than a district at the 10th percentile. The results suggest that while imports can moderate national price spikes, their stabilizing effects may be limited by incomplete internal market integration.